

Wash Your Hands! What Patients and Parents Need to Know About Norovirus



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It's something we all fear, especially this time of year: You or a family member might have been exposed to the "stomach bug." Maybe it's a note from school or daycare, a message from a coworker, or a text from a friend you just visited.

In these instances, the "stomach bug" could be referring to a number of stomach illnesses or **gastroenteritis**. Gastroenteritis refers to an inflammation of your stomach and intestines, sometimes leading to nausea, vomiting, and diarrhea. Often, the stomach bug that causes the gastroenteritis is **norovirus**, a highly contagious RNA virus.

Norovirus causes an average of **19 to 21 million illnesses** a year in the United States alone. Anyone can get norovirus, but children under the age of 5 and adults aged 65 or older are especially at risk. Most infections occur in the colder months of the year. It's important to understand some specifics about the virus to help minimize its impact and its spread to others. Here's what patients and parents need to know.

Norovirus is highly contagious

Norovirus is very contagious. Most infections are transmitted by person-to-person contact, particularly through direct or indirect contact with infected stool or vomit.

It takes a remarkably small amount of the virus to infect many people, which is why it is so contagious. It's also why it can easily cause outbreaks in contained areas, such as cruise ships, daycare centers, and restaurants. Each year, there are about **2,500 reported norovirus outbreaks** in the United States.

Norovirus does not cause flu-like symptoms

People sometimes call norovirus the “stomach flu,” but that’s not accurate. Norovirus typically causes vomiting, abdominal cramps, and diarrhea. Children tend to have more vomiting than diarrhea, whereas adults tend to have more diarrhea. Vomiting and diarrhea can lead to **dehydration**, which may be severe. Symptoms start 1 to 2 days after infection and last 1 to 3 days. People are most contagious immediately after they develop symptoms, and they continue to be most contagious for about 48 hours after symptoms resolve. When returning to school or work, follow all policies and wash your hands thoroughly and regularly.

People will sometimes have fever, headache, and body aches, but not to the same degree typically seen with the flu. What’s more, the flu vaccine will not protect individuals from norovirus. Symptoms like a cough and a high fever may indicate the condition is something other than norovirus.

Norovirus can be life-threatening

On average, norovirus causes **900 deaths** in the United States each year, mostly among adults aged 65 and older. Parents should pay close attention to symptoms in children, particularly infants, because dehydration can occur more quickly in them. Anyone whose immune system is compromised should also be careful.

Usually, the only treatment needed for norovirus gastroenteritis is getting bed rest and drinking adequate amounts of fluid. Even a person who is vomiting should drink as much as can be tolerated. Taking small, frequent sips is helpful. It’s best to drink fluids other than water. Drinks with electrolytes or chicken broth work well. Sports drinks often contain more sugar than salt-containing rehydration solutions, so they’re not ideal. If you or someone in your family starts to experience symptoms of dehydration (dark yellow urine, parched inside of mouth), seek medical attention right away.

Many people won’t see a doctor for norovirus. Because it’s a virus, antibiotics are not needed. Antidiarrheal medications can help, but people should talk to their doctor before taking them.

Washing your hands is the best defense

Washing your hands thoroughly with soap and warm water is the most important step you can take to prevent the spread of norovirus. Hand sanitizers do not kill norovirus. Washing your hands can help keep you from getting sick with norovirus. If you’re already sick, washing your hands (especially after using

the bathroom and before preparing food) can help prevent the spread to others.

If you or someone else in your house has norovirus, maintain distance as much as possible, wash soiled clothing and sheets thoroughly, and use chlorine- or bleach-based cleaners on countertops.

There are other important steps to take to prevent the spread of norovirus. Practice good food hygiene, including washing hands before touching food, washing knives and cutting boards used to cut raw meat before contact with other food, cooking meat and eggs thoroughly, and refrigerating leftovers promptly after cooking. It's also important to avoid questionable foods, particularly oysters and other raw seafood. Finally, pay attention to food recalls for purchases you may need to throw away.

To learn more about norovirus, visit the [Manuals page](#).

